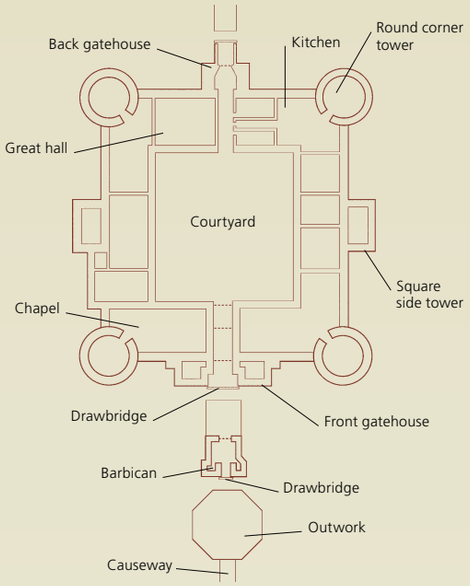
MEDIEVAL CASTLE

Fortifications were ubiquitous in medieval Europe, from the high walls and citadels that protected major towns to the castles that served as military strongpoints and administrative centres. Bodiam Castle in southern England, constructed during the Hundred Years' War, is an example of a fortified individual dwelling – the residence of a wealthy knight, Sir Edward Dallingridge, who believed his home was at risk from attack by the French.

Castle design evolved continuously through the medieval period. Originally European castles were built of wood and earth. The adoption of stone as a construction material from the 11th century made them more expensive to build but far more enduring and prestigious structures, immune to fire and rot. The earliest stone castles consisted of a central tower, or "keep", which was encircled by a defensive wall. By the time Bodiam was built in 1385, however, towers had been integrated into the walls and the gatehouse had become the most strongly defended position in the fortifications. A castle was a visual statement of the wealth, power, and prestige of its owner. But it was also a practical military structure, skilfully designed to give its defenders the best chance of holding off an enemy. Its walls and towers had to be resistant to stone-throwing siege engines, and difficult for tunnel-digging engineers to undermine. The increasing use of cannon in the 15th century eventually made the high, thick stone walls of the medieval castle obsolete, for they could not withstand the battering of such powerful projectiles.



Bodiam Castle
Built around a courtyard, Bodiam Castle had round towers at each corner, square towers on each side, and fortified gatehouses at both the front and the back.

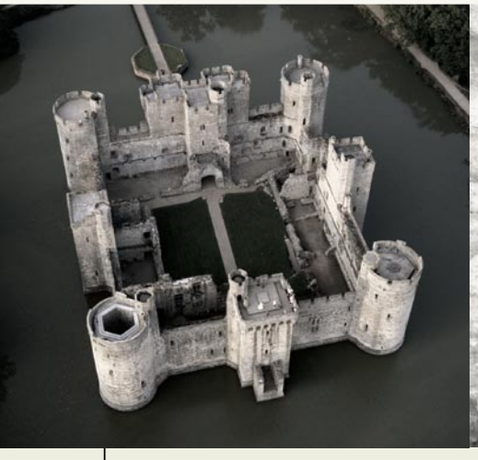


Knight in armour
A castle was stocked with armour and weapons. Full plate armour and visored helmets of sophisticated shape came into use in the 15th century.

> "AT BODIAM, NO TRACE OF THE MODERN WORLD APPEARS TO INVADE THE ANCIENT AND SOLITARY BEAUTY OF THE SCENE."
>
> **LORD CURZON OF KEDDLESTON**, 1859–1925



Siege engine
The torsion-powered ballista was inherited by medieval Europe from the Roman Empire. It was, in effect, a powerful crossbow.



Water obstacle
An aerial view shows how the moat would force any attacker to advance up the narrow causeway at the front of the castle.



Castle gate
The main gate was a potential weak point, since it could succumb to a battering ram. The gate would be protected during a siege by lowering the iron portcullis.



Stone shields
Heraldic shields carved above the castle gates were meant to impress visitors with the owner's status. Many owners, however, were in fact minor knights grown rich on plunder.



Battlements
Corbels support the battlements, which have crenels (gaps) used by archers.